

SPLIT WIDE OPEN

PIB

<< REWIND

India's grand old party, the Congress, faced its first major split as the old guard led by party President, S. Nijalingappa expelled Prime Minister Indira Gandhi from the party for "fostering a cult of personality". The "Syndicate", as the senior members were called, could not quite come to terms with the fact that the "*gunji gudiya*" (dumb doll)—their snide reference for Indira—had a mind of her own. The break was complete when Indira after proposing N. Sanjeeva Reddy's name for presidency asked Congressmen to "vote according to their conscience". V.V. Giri, the rebel Congress candidate won.

THE NEW ORDER: Indira with V.V. Giri; Zakir Hussain (below)

Death of a President

When the communal temperature was at its peak in India, the country had a Muslim president and a Muslim chief justice of the Supreme Court. After serving as vice-president to the great Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan for five years, Zakir Hussain, an academic and former vice-chancellor of the Aligarh Muslim University, became the philosopher scholar's successor at Rashtrapathi Bhavan in 1967. Hussain however had one of the briefest terms as the country's president as he died less than two years later. He was also the first Indian president to die in office.



FIRST CUT

- The first superfast train, Rajdhani Express, was introduced between New Delhi and Howrah, with an average speed of 130 kmph.

- India's first atomic power station at Tarapore became operational.

- The state of Madras was renamed Tamil Nadu.

1,516 sq km

was the area covered by the Gir Forest Reserve of Gujarat, established in 1969. It was set up to protect lions in India, whose numbers had dwindled.